

Johanna over the fate of his nine-year-old nephew, Karl. A custody battle in the courts lasted until 1820, with the child suffering long-term emotional damage.

Late masterpieces

Despite his deafness, Beethoven delivered a glorious “late period” of innovative, intellectually demanding music. It was heralded by the “Hammerklavier” Sonata in 1818, one of the most technically and emotionally challenging works in the entire piano repertoire. Other masterpieces followed, including the three last piano sonatas, written between 1820 and 1822, and the magnificent choral Missa Solemnis, completed in 1823. Part of the Missa Solemnis was performed at the same concert that premiered Beethoven’s Ninth Symphony in Vienna in May 1824. Unprecedented orchestral forces had been assembled for the occasion, along with the choir and soloists for the symphony’s last-movement setting of Friedrich Schiller’s “Ode to Joy.” The concert was a triumph, although Beethoven himself could hear neither the music nor the rapturous applause.

“I shall hear in heaven.”

LUDWIG VAN BEETHOVEN, REPORTED AS HIS LAST
WORDS, MARCH 1827

The reception of the Ninth Symphony showed the considerable status that Beethoven still enjoyed. However, he was no longer the composer of the moment—rather, a revered figure from the past. Even the most